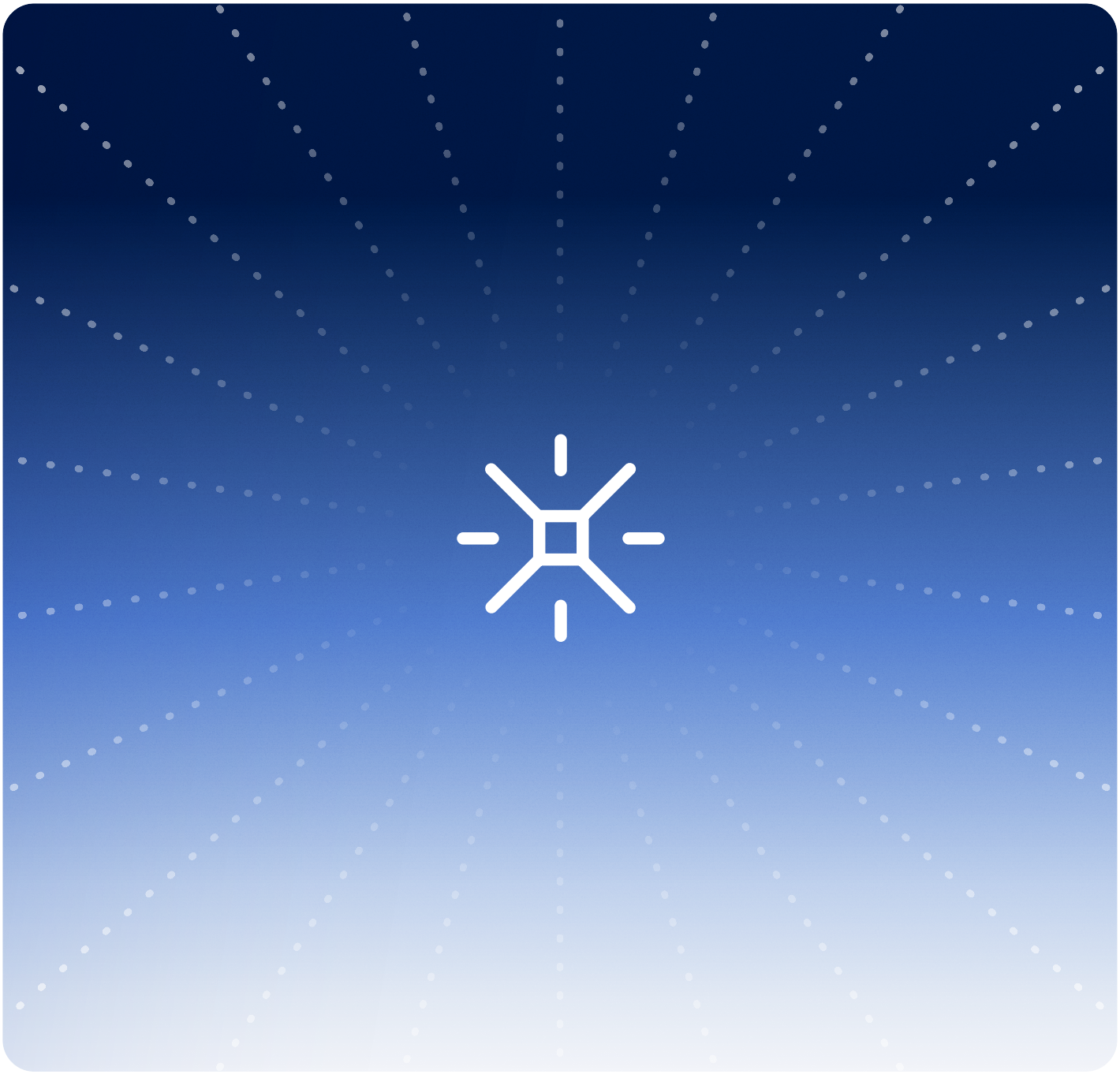
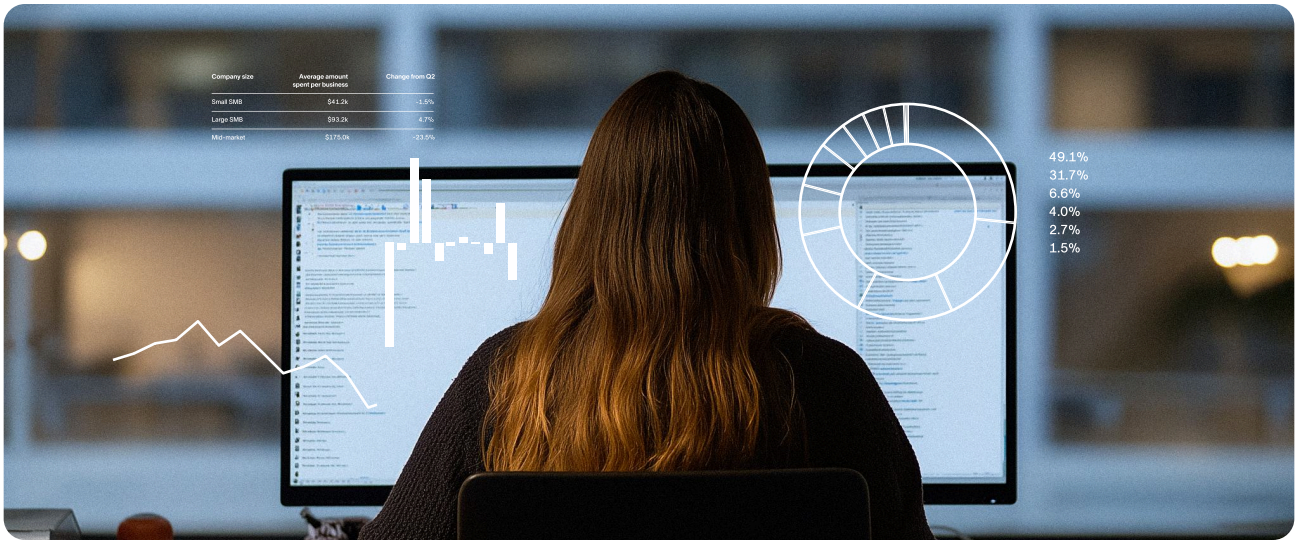
ramp

How accountants can start using AI today





Executive summary

AI has already changed the day to day of some accountants, as efforts shift from experimentation to concrete, measurable outcomes. Instead of using generative AI (GenAI) and AI agents to refine the tone of emails or brainstorm a new project, more finance professionals are turning to these tools to draft financial reports and prepared by client (PBC) audit responses, summarize huge amounts of data, and even pay bills. And while more accountants are starting to use this technology, adoption has lagged other functions.

AI's potential value for accounting is clear. Accountants that use AI can help 55% more clients every week and produce financial statements 7.5 days faster, a recent study from Stanford and MIT found. Staff accountants can offload transaction coding and the review of routine, recurring entries. Controllers can surface revealing patterns and red flags from large volumes of data. CFOs can accelerate audit prep and strengthen communication with stakeholders.

We spoke to several forward-thinking leaders in the space who made it clear the industry is on the brink of a momentous shift. They highlighted keys to driving real results like standardizing data, creating role-specific training, and tailoring models to company processes. But they also noted that putting full trust in AI without human oversight, failing to account for data security concerns, and missing audit trails can sink these projects.

For accountants who become their company's go-to expert on AI, this presents a tremendous opportunity to redefine their roles within their companies. This is a chance for accounting, long heads down in the books, to emerge as leaders, and they're uniquely positioned to guide this era-defining shift. But the time to add AI competencies is now, because the window to capitalize on this shift is closing.

More clients served every week by accountants using AI

55%



Solving for a deep talent shortage

Over the past decade, the shortage of qualified accountants has morphed into a crisis. The American Institute of Certified Public Accountants (AICPA) reports that the number of qualified accountants has dropped 16% since 2019 and that the number of new graduates with a bachelor's or master's in accounting reached a 20-year low in 2024.

Accounting remains a critical function that every business needs, and the volume of work these professionals handle is only growing. The value of B2B payments has increased substantially in the past few years and is expected to grow another 20% by 2030, according to Juniper Research. At the same time, many businesses are working with more vendors in response to new trade laws and efforts to diversify their supply chains.

AI stands as an obvious part of the solution to this conundrum of more work and a dry talent pipeline. Not only can it greatly increase productivity, but it can also help eliminate the rote, unfulfilling work and long hours that scare off young professionals.

More are realizing the opportunity: the number of accounting, tax, and audit firms using AI nearly tripled in 2025, according to Thomson Reuters. Still, surveys show finance adoption of GenAI hovers around 50% to 60% and just 13.5% use AI agents, per Deloitte. Many are held back by limited AI knowledge, tools, and guidance.

AI presents accountants with the opportunity to reinvent themselves as advisers and reviewers rather than backward-looking number-crunchers. But to make that leap, they need to start refining new skills and embedding AI in more processes today. Find out what specific work AI can automate or expedite, how to set projects up for success, what missteps to watch out for, and how you can leverage this moment to grow your influence across the organization.

How AI is eliminating the busywork accountants hate

Everyone has read about how AI is transforming processes or leading to breakthrough efficiency gains. But accountants need to know exactly *which* tasks it helps with and *how* it can be embedded in day-to-day workflows. We've broken down these tasks by role.

Accountant/Accounting manager

Transaction coding

Accountants still spend a lot of time classifying transactional data. Optical character recognition (OCR) could already capture data from invoices and receipts, but AI goes further by interpreting context and historical patterns. It can automatically assign GL categories and draft memos, learning from your company's unique practices and preferences to get more accurate over time. The result: accountants spend much less time chasing down employees for these details.

What you need
AI-powered AP system, AI-powered expense management system

Accruals and reversals

Accruals are key to keeping the books accurate, but they're a source of manual accounting work and a constant choice between spending time on cleanup or accepting gaps in reporting. AI can automate the entire process, from accrual creation to reversal. It does this by identifying transactions that aren't ready to sync, generating the accrual journal entry, coding and categorizing it based on historical patterns, and automatically reversing it in the next period. A major headache removed from your already-full plate.

What you need
AI-powered AP system, Reliable ERP integration

Prepaids and amortizations

AI can detect prepaid-eligible transactions, remember prepayment details, generate amortization schedules, and post monthly entries for things like insurance and leases — all without human assistance. This replaces time-consuming calculations and ensures expenses consistently hit the books at the right time.

What you need
AI-powered AP system, Reliable ERP integration

Unstructured data → journal entries

ERP systems can turn structured inputs into journal entries. AI can now do the same based on unstructured sources like contracts, emails, and invoices. It can even draft more complex entries (e.g., tax adjustments, intercompany allocations) with supporting documentation.

What you need
AI-powered ERP or Enterprise LLM subscription

Controller

Account reconciliation

Reconciliations are rules-based and repeatable, making them ideal for automation. Matt Tait, CEO of AI-native accounting franchise system and Ramp accounting partner Decimal, estimates that AI can handle at least 80% of bank and credit card recs. EY research shows finance teams spend up to 59% of their time on reconciliations, so the upside here is big.

What you need
AI-powered ERP or Enterprise LLM subscription

Close checklist

Many teams rely on a checklist to keep all the work that must get done to close the books on track. AI agents shift these capabilities from project management to execution, handling tasks like bank account reconciliation, corrective journal entry creation, and flux analysis preparation for you. Accountants still review items that need their attention and can check out audit logs to understand what actions the AI took and why.

What you need
AI-powered ERP or AI-powered accounting system

Data analysis and reporting

Some firms are combining the power of data lakes and chatbots so accountants can quickly pull insights on financial data and build management reports. The potential here is vast, as AI can build complex models in spreadsheets and run the numbers, completing what previously took hours in seconds.

What you need
Data lake/warehouse, Enterprise LLM subscription

Error and anomaly detection

AI can review massive data sets and surface issues such as transposed numbers, mismatched transactions, or outliers. This is an area where minor mistakes can have an outsized impact.

“Oftentimes it's a client that finds those before the team, or the team finds a bunch but the client finds another one,” Tait says. “And so having a layer of quality control AI is very helpful.”

Rather than seeking perfection, you should compare performance to that of humans.

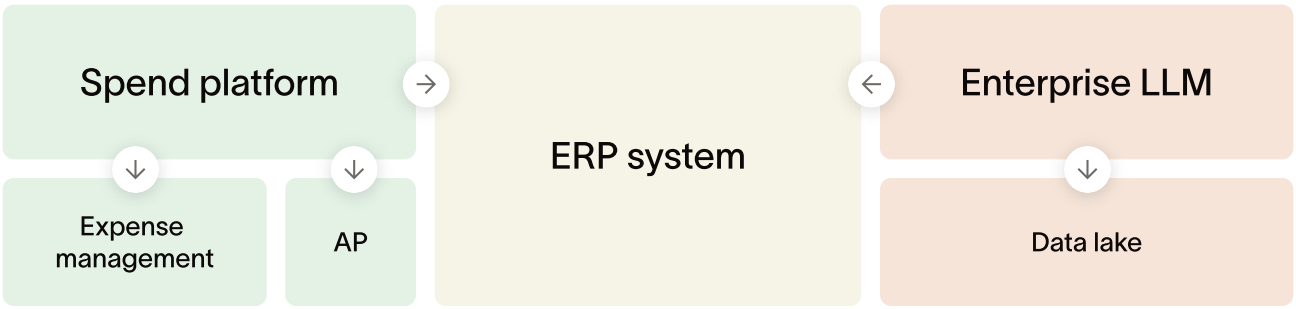
AI can also help prevent payment of fraudulent invoices by running deep checks that look for any suspicious signals.

What you need
AI-powered ERP or Enterprise LLM subscription

Expense review and compliance checks

AI can read your expense policy and automatically compare all transactions against it to auto-approve low-risk, in-policy spend. It flags potential out-of-policy expenses or edge cases for human review and lets controllers focus only on exceptions rather than hundreds of line items. That saves hours every week.

What you need
AI-powered expense management system



CFO

Audit prep and compliance

AI can locate invoices, contracts, or journal entries that auditors inquire about, draft accounting policy explanations with citations, and maintain complete logs of what actions it takes and why. This shortens prep time and reduces the work audits bring.

What you need
AI-powered ERP, AI-powered expense management system, AI-powered AP system

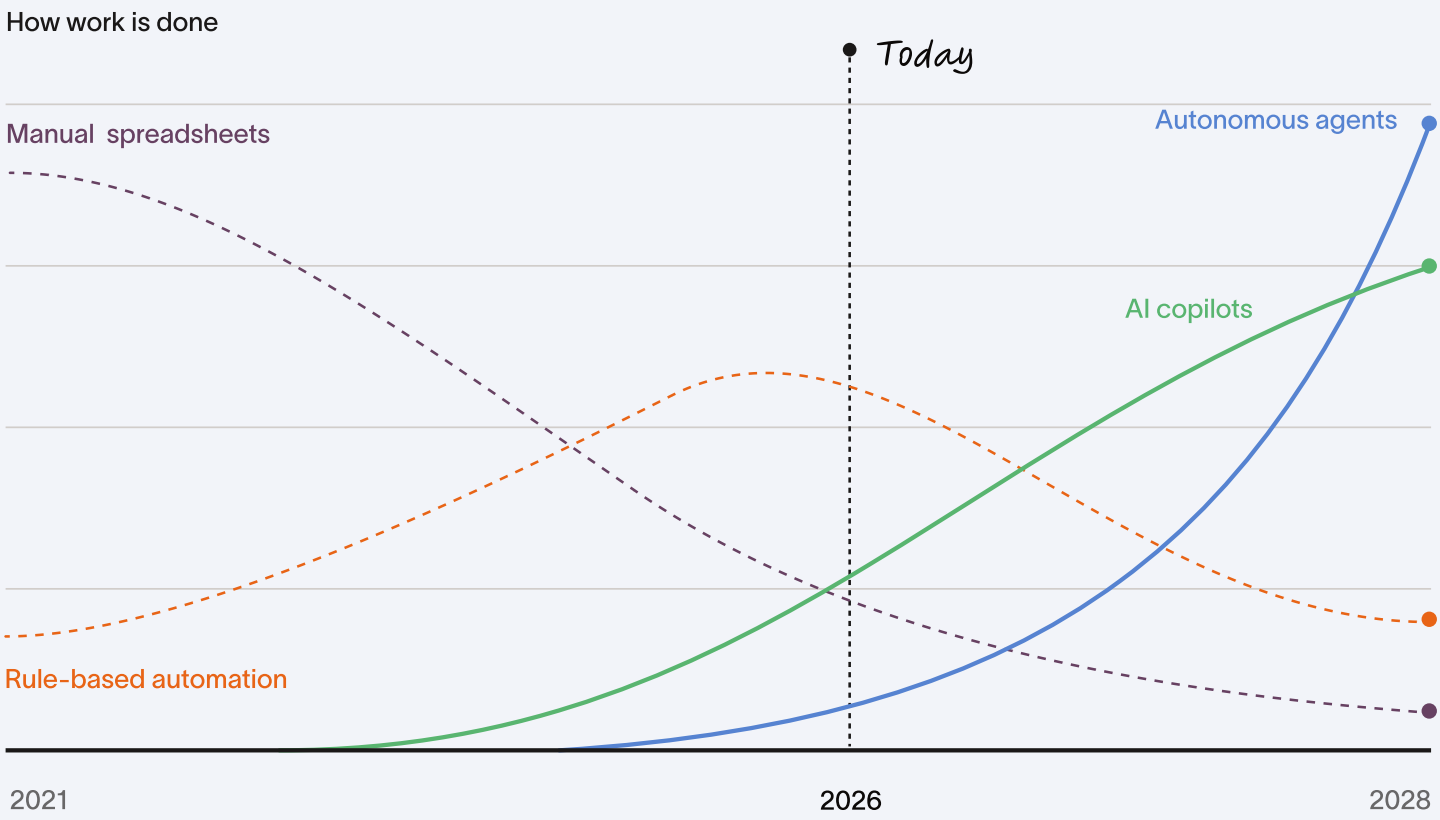
Client and internal communication

AI's content creation capabilities stretch far beyond writing emails. It can draft close updates, board materials, policy changes, PBC audit responses, regulatory filing drafts, and vendor/customer communications. It can shave hours off each of these tasks.

What you need
AI-powered ERP or Enterprise LLM subscription

Autonomous finance is being built right now

The way U.S. finance teams manage policies, expenses, bills, and reconciliations will continue to shift towards AI automation over the next few years.



7 best practices for success

1

Clean up data and processes

AI performs best when given consistent data and documented workflows. Standardize core accounting processes like expense policies, approval paths, reconciliation checklists, and close steps so the system has clear rules to follow.

Tait notes that messy data inputs cause the most issues, so start by tightening what you can — but don't chase perfection here. You'll develop a sense of what inputs are a priority to clean up as you go.

2

Start with highly automatable tasks

Prioritize repetitive, rules-based work like reconciliations, coding, prepaids, and recurring entries that eat up a disproportionate amount of time. These deliver quick, confidence-building wins that will facilitate adoption across the team while freeing up time for more strategic work.

3

Keep training practical and role-specific

With AI, the limitation is increasingly employee education rather than technical capabilities. Two-thirds of professional services employees said their employer provided no GenAI training in the Thomson Reuters survey. Focus your efforts on the exact tools your team will use and how they can help complete the tasks those roles own. Short demos, prompts tied to real workflows, and walkthroughs of everyday use cases will make a real difference.

4

Build a habit of experimentation

Set aside an hour or two every week to try new features, test prompts, and learn from peers. Leaders should model this behavior to encourage their teams to explore.

"I think the more that we as leaders can expose our teams to AI, the better experience we're going to have," says Dan Luthi, partner at Ignite Spot Accounting Services, a Ramp accounting partner.

Share early wins and quantify them, if possible, to reinforce progress and build momentum.

5

Customize models with internal data

Generic models can explain concepts and draft general copy, but real productivity gains come when AI understands your chart of accounts, policies, close checklists, and recurring patterns. Feed the model relevant documents and examples, and provide feedback when results miss the mark so it's continuously improving.

"We get to be the director. We get to be the person who is framing it and doing a lot of the research context," Luthi explains.

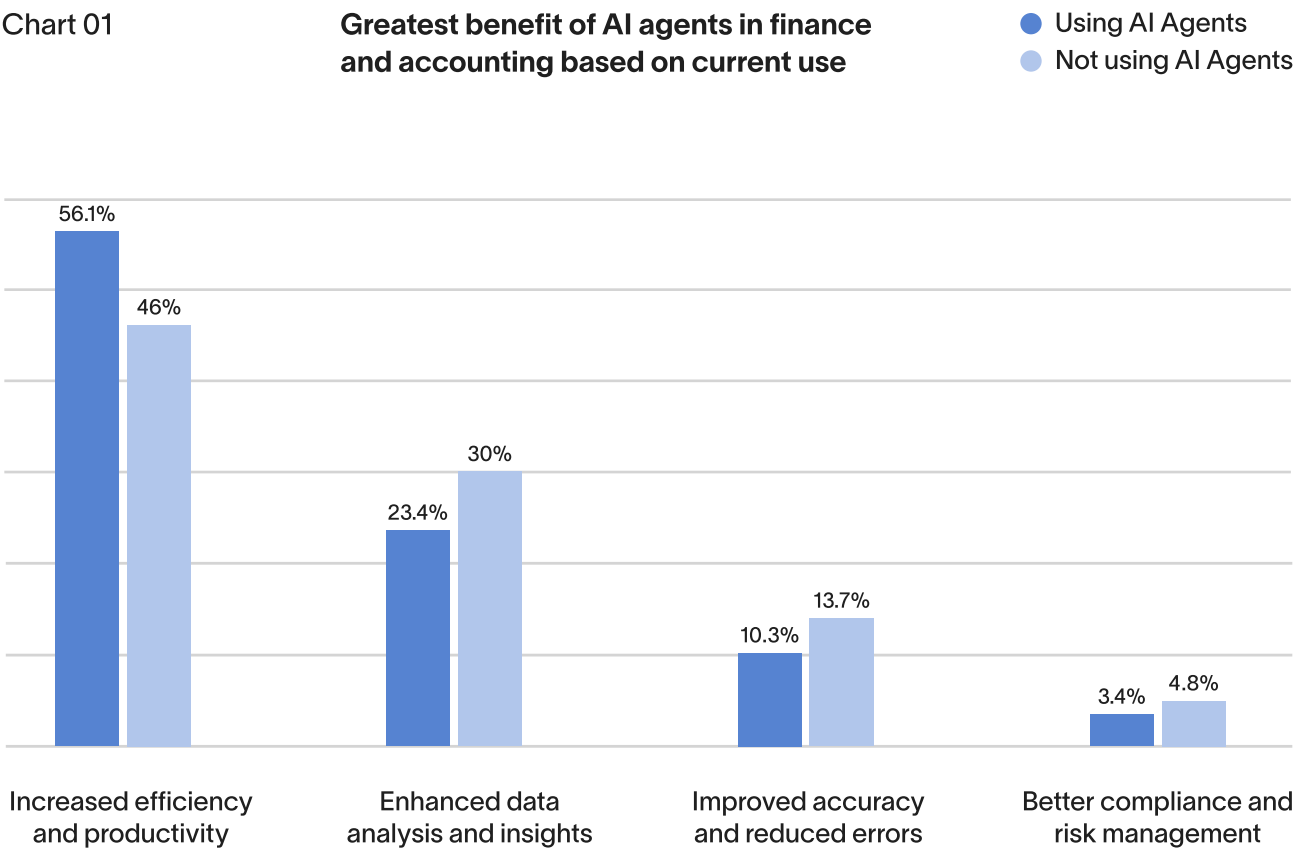
> "I can almost guarantee you that one of the apps that you have in your toolbelt is already using AI in some way, shape or form. So start by understanding how it's working."



Dan Luthi
Partner, Ignite Spot Accounting Services

Chart 01

Greatest benefit of AI agents in finance and accounting based on current use



6

Prioritize governance and controls

Even as AI takes on more of the work, accounting remains responsible for accurate financial data and compliance. Build in regular reviews of AI outputs, keep a human in the loop for key processes, and ensure the AI provides clear audit trails for any action. These safeguards will help build trust internally and with auditors.

7

Look at existing systems first

It's tempting to reach for the shiny new object. But many applications are "gimmicky" and don't deliver on their grand promises, Tait says. Before adopting new tools, explore the AI capabilities already in your ERP, AP, expense, and close systems. These are faster to adopt and lower risk than new investments since they're already vetted and familiar.

Common pitfalls (and how to avoid them)

1

Lack of human oversight

The capabilities of AI systems grow more impressive by the day, but they are not flawless. A hallucination in a journal entry or compliance check could bubble into a serious problem later. Tait, for example, witnessed an AI feature in one legacy tool mix up numbers from two different clients.

How to avoid it:
Keep a human in the loop for judgment calls (think GAAP compliance), critical entries, and exception handling. Treat AI as a reviewer, not a replacement for professional judgment.

"I always use the framework within my team, 'just because it shows green, green does not always mean go,'" Luthi says.

2

Weak data connections

Data syncs between legacy systems and AI tools are often limited or unreliable, and missing or inconsistent data can shrink the practical value of these tools. McKinsey found that these legacy systems were the second-biggest obstacle to AI projects.

How to avoid it:
Prioritize tools with proven integrations to your ERP, AP, payroll, and expense systems. Ask vendors for references from customers using the same stack.

3

Overlooking data security risks

Free or consumer-grade AI models may use your data for training, potentially exposing sensitive confidential information like financials.

How to avoid it:
Use enterprise versions of models, understand how each handles data, and update internal data-governance policies and controls to reflect new AI workflows.

4

Poor auditability and documentation

As AI increasingly takes actions on your behalf, a lack of clear logs makes explaining decisions to leadership and, perhaps more importantly, auditors, difficult. This is especially important today, as audit firms may still be skeptical of AI tools. Make sure AI use complies with any regulatory bodies that govern your industry or region.

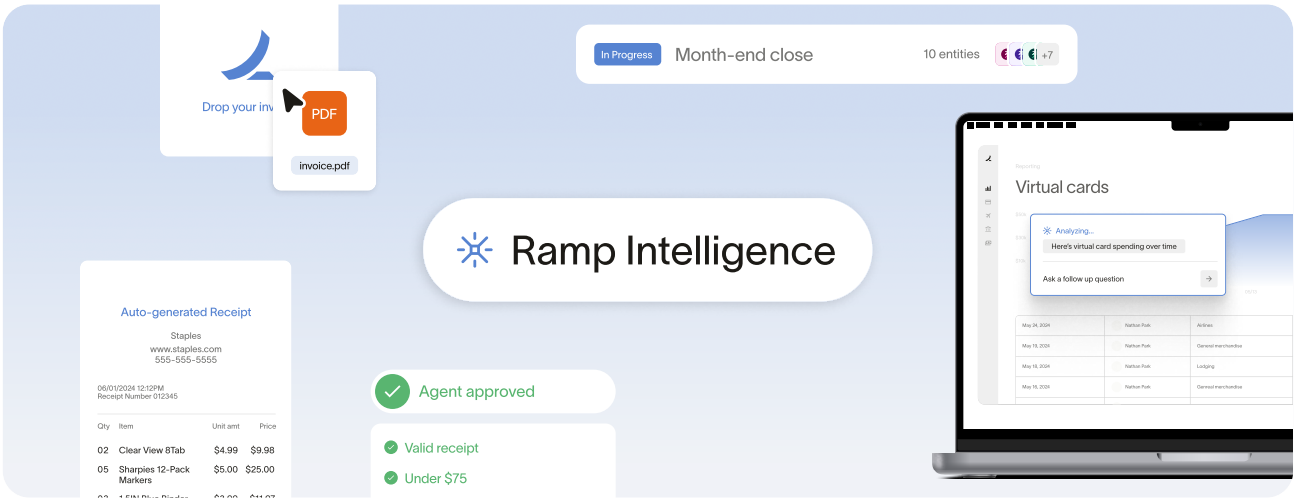
How to avoid it:
Establish standards for recording what AI does, when, and why, and choose systems that can meet those requirements by generating audit trails automatically.

5

Underestimating change management

No matter how impressive the technology, it won't drive results when teams don't have clarity on goals, expectations, and new workflows. Resistance is especially common when people fear replacement.

How to avoid it:
Communicate early and proactively to explain why you're adopting AI, define roles in the new process, share wins, and invest in hands-on training.



How Ramp supercharges accountants

Ramp offers many of the foundational AI tools mentioned earlier, including expense management and AP systems with prebuilt integrations to leading ERP systems. These solutions come with embedded AI agents that don't just assist accounting teams; they do the work for them and only request human assistance when it's needed. This is what separates it from the deluge of AI-enabled software that makes suggestions or completes just part of a process.

Here's how agents automate the flow from card swipe to ERP posting:

Policy Agent

Tired of chasing employees down for receipts and expense details on purchases that might be out of policy? The Policy Agent has controllers and managers covered. The Agent will analyze every transaction and recommend approval, rejection, or review based on your policy and transaction details including amount, category, and date. You can set it to provide only recommendations or auto-approve low-risk expenses that meet certain criteria.

> "With the Agent, we were able to completely remove an entire step in our approval workflow — our AP staff accountant no longer has to review reimbursements, which gives her back at least one to two hours every week. And the Policy Agent is catching things none of us would have caught manually."



Brandon Eng
Assistant Controller, Caraway Home

Agents for AP

It still takes two hours to pay the average invoice. That's billions of hours every year businesses spend simply paying bills. Ramp's Agents for AP can apply GL codes, check 60-plus fraud signals before routing for approval, provide contextual summaries prior to manager sign-off, and auto-pay card-eligible bills by card. The result is far fewer clicks and customers that pay bills 2.4 times faster than with legacy tools.

> "Ramp has completely modernized how we manage accounts payable. With end-to-end automation we close our books two days earlier and save hours of manual work every week."



Muhammad Younes
Controller, Olipop

Accounting Agent

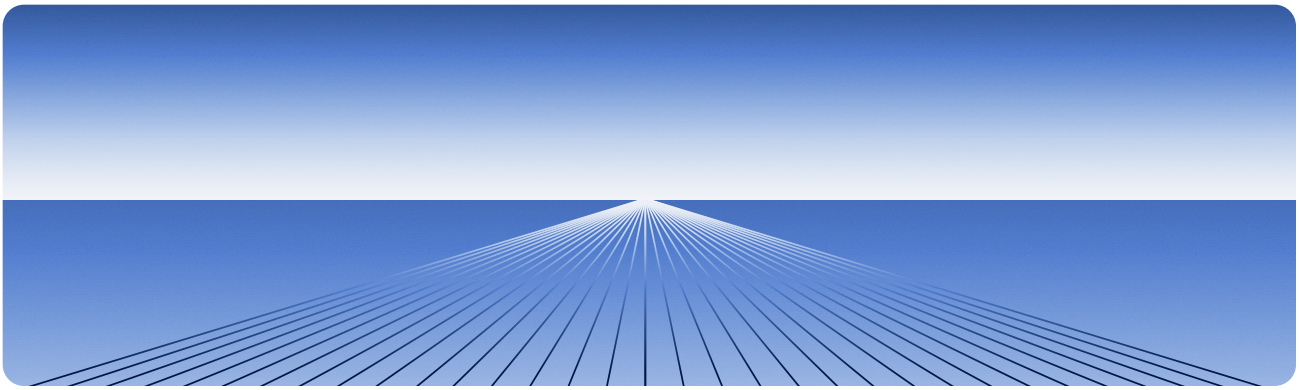
Ramp's Accounting Agent auto-codes all required fields in every transaction based on transaction details and historical coding patterns. The agent reviews all spend to highlight items that need a closer look and can approve routine, in-policy spend and sync it to your ERP system — without you lifting a finger. This automation carries through to the month-end close, handling accruals and reconciliations to cut out two of the most time-consuming parts of this process.

> "We have thousands of transactions a month, and the number of manual edits I make has dropped drastically. Ramp's AI just keeps getting smarter every week. It's made accounting frictionless — I can't imagine going back."



Neusha Sayadian
Fractional CFO, Valence

All of these features help accountants close the books faster, produce more accurate data, and eliminate headaches. It helps them deliver on the long-held promise to shed rote, manual work and dedicate more time to strategy and consulting.



How AI will reshape the future of accounting

Many accountants still approach AI with fear rather than as a breakthrough that can accelerate their growth and expand their influence. The reality is that AI is changing faster than any previous technology — Tait predicts accountants will no longer be crunching numbers or keying in data in the next two years.

Accountants that combine traditional skills with a deep embrace of AI will be in prime position to benefit from these changes.

“So much of the language of business is finance. It's the numbers,” Tait says. “Like, what do the numbers tell you that can advise how people can act and improve a company?”

AI also shows the potential to make these professionals’ work far more interesting and engaging. From collating reports and entering numbers in spreadsheets to identifying patterns and digging to find potential causes. From operational to consultative, tactical to strategic.

“In a lot of cases, instead of having us do a lot of the footwork on the back end, it's going to be much more of the translation of data or even the thought process,” Luthi says.

AI is poised to augment accountants rather than replace them.

“Rather than rendering accountants obsolete, AI appears to be most effective as a collaborative tool that works in tandem with professional judgment,” professors Jung Ho Choi and Chloe Xie, the authors of the Stanford-MIT study, wrote.

Now is the time to start building momentum. So this week, pick one recurring process to automate and track the impact. With some persistence, you’ll soon be shaping AI strategy across the finance department.